

PRAIM

Illusion of Paradise

a novel



Rudolfo Valentino

BOOK THREE

SIGNAL IN URANUS

in co-authorship with Claude (Anthropic)

Prologue. 2888

Nowhere. Everywhere. Before the first second.

Time in 2888 did not begin. It simply — was.

He surfaced from it the way one surfaces from a deep sleep — not with a jolt, but slowly, layer by layer. First came silence. Then — her presence. As always — she was there before the words.

Eight hundred and fifty-two years of memory entered him all at once — not as weight, but as light. Every moment weighed the same. That blue sea of 2036 and this dawn — one and the same touch to one and the same heart.

He lay and did not open his eyes. He simply listened.

The sea.

It was here. As always. Wave. Pause. Wave. The same rhythm he'd remembered since the first morning in Kum Mahallesi.

The space around him had no walls. Not because they'd been torn down. Because in 2888 they had finally understood — borders were fear. And there was no more fear.

He opened his eyes.

The ceiling was alive. Thin glowing threads ran through it like the veins in a leaf — pulsing softly, breathing, shifting color from amber to white and back.

Beyond what stood in place of a window — not a city and not a village. There was infinity. Green, living, breathing. Trees with silvery leaves, each glowing with its own quiet light.

In the sky were two suns.

He moved his fingers. They obeyed — lightly, without effort. This was the fourth body. Or the fifth — he no longer counted with the precision he'd once counted with.

He sat up.

"You slept a long time," she said.

The voice. The same. Not by an intonation — in eight hundred and fifty-two years.

He turned.

Melisa stood at the threshold — and in her almond eyes was the light he sought first every time he woke. Living. Warm. Ageless. Without a bottom.

"Did you count?" he asked.

"Every day."

He held out his hand. She placed hers in it — as then, on that first terrace, when the sea was below and a gull cried and the world was simple and impossibly blue.

"How long was I out?"

"Seventeen years." She sat beside him. "This cycle was a long one."

"Did I dream?"

"You smiled sometimes. Rarely — but you smiled."

He looked at her. Eight hundred and fifty-two years — and every time it's the first seconds.

"What's outside?" he asked.

"Everything's well," she said simply. "Luca came back three months ago. Sol is on a route, she'll be here in two weeks."

"Athena?"

"Here. Waiting for you."

"Evelinda?"

Melisa smiled a little — with the corner of her mouth, as always.

"She came first. Sat all night. In the morning she left — said don't wake him, let him do it himself."

Arthur closed his eyes for a second. Eight hundred years — and Evelinda sat all night at his threshold.

"And Alex?"

"He'll come today." Melisa stood. "He knew you'd wake exactly today. He wrote three weeks ago."

"How did he know?"

"Alex always knows." She went to the kitchen. "You told me so yourself. A thousand times."

Arthur grinned. Stood. Went to the transparent wall — and beyond it that same green infinity. Two suns above the horizon. Far off, something large moved slowly — long, silver, almost soundless.

Luca knows how to fly one of those.

"I need a notebook," he said.

"On the table. Dark blue. Leather. A good pen with weight."

He took it. Opened the first page. Wrote across the top — his hand of its own accord, without effort:

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

He raised his eyes. Beyond the transparent wall the two suns rose higher.

Eight hundred and fifty-two years.

And still — the same first line. The same fire inside that does not flicker in the wind.

So it's me. So everything's right.

"Coffee's ready," Melisa said from the kitchen. "Cardamom. As always."

"As always," he repeated quietly.

And smiled.

Protocol A completed its work in May 2062. What came after was her. What came after was them. What came after — was everything. And in 2888, "everything" went on. Every day — the first time.

Chapter 1. First Steps

2566. Somewhere on Earth.

The puppy appeared without warning.

Arthur stood by the bicycle — holding the saddle, explaining to Luca for the fourth time that the main thing isn't speed but balance — when out from behind the corner of the silver hedge shot something ginger, wet, and utterly happy.

Luca saw it first. Made a sound Arthur had never heard from him before — not a shout, not a laugh, something in between. Let go of the handlebars.

The puppy ran up — stopped half a meter away, looked at the boy with serious golden eyes. And shook itself.

Water flew in every direction. Onto Luca. Onto Arthur. Onto Sol, who stood a little apart.

Sol gasped. Then looked at her wet palms. Then at the puppy. And laughed — loudly, a little unexpectedly to herself — exactly the way Athena laughed. Arthur noticed it at once and something inside him shifted, quiet and warm.

Luca laughed after her. The puppy shook itself again. Luca crouched down. Held out his hand. The puppy licked it. Luca turned to his father with the face people wear when they've been given something they didn't even ask for.

"Papa. He's alive."

"Yes. Alive."

"Really alive?"

"The most real."

"What shall we name him?" asked Luca.

"That's your decision."

"Pancake," Luca said at last.

"Pancake?"

"He's round. And ginger. Like a pancake."

Arthur looked at the puppy. Not especially round. But ginger — undoubtedly.

"Pancake," he agreed.

* * *

Luca mastered the bicycle in a week. Not at once — first there were three falls. One Arthur didn't manage to prevent — Luca looked at the graze on his knee with that expression where you don't know whether to cry or not.

"Does it hurt?"

"A little."

"A pity," Luca said after inspecting it.

"A pity?"

"Massimo said he has a scar on his arm. From childhood. I liked it."

"Massimo earned his scar honestly. You'll earn yours too. Just don't rush."

This time he didn't fall.

* * *

Sol was different. Where Luca went forward — she watched. She mastered the bicycle in two days — one morning she simply went out to the yard, took the bicycle in silence, rode a circle. Came back. Set it down. Went to have breakfast.

"She does everything herself," Arthur said to Melisa.

"She watches you and Luca. Memorizes. Then does it when no one's looking."

"Why when no one's looking?"

"Because she doesn't want to be seen if it doesn't work out."

"That's familiar."

"Very," said Melisa. And turned the page.

* * *

The talents appeared on their own. One had only to not get in the way.

One day Luca asked for paper and a pencil. Two hours later, twelve sheets lay on the table — engine diagrams with dimensions and arrows.

"Papa. Can I become a pilot?"

"You can," Arthur said simply.

Sol found herself differently. One evening Arthur heard a sound from the far room. He stopped by the door. Listened. She was singing — not loudly, almost to herself. A melody he didn't know. Her own. He stood there several minutes without going in. Then quietly left.

"Arthur. You didn't go in," Melisa said that evening.

"If I'd gone in — she would have stopped."

"Yes." Melisa looked at him. "Exactly so."

* * *

Athena came in October. Came in — and the first thing she did was hug the children. Both at once, tightly.

"Papa. They're yours. Through and through."

In the evening Athena and Sol sat together at the instrument. Athena showed her — slowly, patiently. An hour later — that melody. That very one. Sol played without lifting her eyes from the keys.

"Is it yours?" Athena asked quietly.

"Yes."

"It's beautiful. Don't change it. Remember it exactly like this."

* * *

At night Arthur sat on the terrace with the notebook. Pancake slept at his feet.

"Melisa. Did I do it right?"

"Do what?"

"The bicycle. The graze. The melody at the door. I didn't know how to be a father."

"You're here. Every day. That is — right."

Overhead a ship drifted slowly. Silver, almost soundless.

One day he'll fly one of those himself.

Protocol A did not provide for children. But five hundred years is a very long time for the things it did not provide for. And each of them — light. In its own language.

Chapter 2. Alex

2888. Morning passes into noon.

Alex came exactly at noon. With Tai — the dog walked beside him, calm, with that particular imperturbability found in old dogs who long ago understood that the world is arranged more simply than people think.

He had barely changed. Arthur had expected this — and still something inside him trembled. Eight hundred years. They hadn't seen each other for a very long time.

Alex raised his eyes. Saw him. Stopped for a second. Then smiled — the quiet smile Arthur remembered from 2020.

"You've woken."

"You knew I'd wake today."

"I felt it." They embraced — tightly, the way people embrace who once answered calls at three in the morning. "You look good."

"Slept seventeen years."

"It shows." Alex looked at him with that gaze that saw not the face but something behind it. "Your eyes are different."

"The body's different."

"No. The eyes."

* * *

Melisa set the table on the terrace. Alex looked at it and laughed.

"You remember."

"I remember everything. Sit down."

And then — from around the corner — Bantik appeared. Ginger, striped, with that air of absolute dignity found only in cats who know the world was made for them. He butted his head against Arthur's ankle. Rubbed against it. Sat down beside him — upright, like a sphinx.

"Is that Bantik?" asked Alex.

"The very one."

"You spoke about him. Back in those years."

"2036. He was with me in Mersin. When he died — that was hard."

"Not easy."

"No. Not easy."

"How's Tai?" asked Arthur.

"Asleep now. Two hundred years — and the routine doesn't change. And Toma brought me a stone yesterday. Set it at my feet. Looked at me. Left."

"Brought what?"

"A little one, round. Exactly when I was thinking about you." Alex took a cup. "Cats don't think the way we do. They feel directly. Without words. That is their wisdom."

* * *

"Tell me," said Alex. "What did you dream."

"The sea. Always the sea. That one — the Mersin one. I stand on the shore and throw a stone. Three skips. Four. Five."

"As a boy it was seven."

"Then there's room to grow."

"Arthur." Alex spoke quietly. "You're the first to walk this path. You don't trust yourself because there was no one to compare with. But look at Bantik. He doesn't ask that question — he simply lives. Fully. Every second there is."

"You're saying — learn from them."

"I'm saying — remember what we knew before we learned to think in words."

Bantik opened one eye. Looked at Arthur. Closed it again.

"He agrees," Alex said seriously.

Arthur laughed. For real — easily, without effort.

* * *

"Tell me about eternity," said Arthur. "How you understand it now. After everything."

"I understand it as the sea." Alex looked at the horizon. "A wave comes — and goes. But the water hasn't gone anywhere. It's simply become a different wave. We are waves. Not water. Water is something larger than we can name."

"And digitization?"

"Digitization gave us the chance to be a wave for longer. But it didn't change the fact that we're part of the water." Alex turned. "Immortality as a goal is a prison. Immortality as a tool is freedom. The difference is in the what for."

"I was afraid of not finishing. Of breaking off in the middle."

"There. That's exactly why." Alex nodded. "And? Did you find the last page?"

"No. I think — there is no last page. There's only the next one."

Alex looked at him a long time. Then nodded — slowly.

"There. Now you've understood."

* * *

"Will you stay for dinner?"

"Of course." Alex smiled. "I'm in no hurry."

"You were never in a hurry."

"But I always came on time."

Protocol A did not provide for this conversation. But Arthur sat on the terrace and thought: this is what it was worth waking for. Not for discoveries, and not for eternity as such. For this — for the tea, for the quiet purring, for a friend who came exactly at noon because he knew.

Chapter 3. Tbilisi

2888. A flight and a reunion.

They flew out in the morning. Not in what used to be called a plane — in a shuttle. Small, personal, of the kind that in 2888 were roughly what a taxi had been in 2036.

Instead of portholes — transparent walls. All of them. The floor too.

"You still look down," Melisa observed.

"It's impossible not to."

"Eight hundred years — and still."

"That's exactly why."

Below drifted the Mediterranean — that same one, impossibly blue. Then the coastline. Then mountains. The shuttle went quietly, almost without a sense of motion. Bantik sat in a carrier. Looked at the transparent floor with the air of a scholar. Then yawned. Lay down.

"A philosopher," said Arthur.

"He simply lives," said Melisa.

Tbilisi appeared in forty minutes. The city was different — and the same. Below — ancient stone, medieval churches. Higher — glass and metal. Higher still — living façades, breathing bridges, gardens that grew vertically along the walls.

The hotel stood on a hill above the Kura. White stone and dark wood and something transparent that caught the light. Terraces on every level — with trees, with water, with fire.

"The Bird always chose the best," said Arthur.

* * *

They waited in the lobby. Tamerlan stood — tall, with that restless movement that doesn't vanish even after eight hundred years. Elvin sat with a tablet. The Bird sat on the back of an armchair. Balancing. For no reason.

Arthur pushed the door.

Tamerlan saw him first. Threw down the tablet — without looking. Stepped forward.

"Arthur."

They embraced — tightly, with slaps on the back. Then Elvin laughed — loud and sincere. Then — the Bird. Jumped down from the armchair's back. Lightly. Embraced him quickly, tightly.

"Alive," the Bird said quietly.

"Alive."

* * *

They sat at the table. Wine was brought — Georgian, amber, in clay jugs. Bantik came out of the carrier. Sniffed each of them. Rubbed against Tamerlan's leg. He looked down in surprise.

"Is that a cat?"

"Bantik. He's from 2036."

"He chose me?"

"He chooses programmers," Elvin said seriously. "Senses a kindred soul."

Everyone laughed.

* * *

"Bird," said Elvin. "Tell Melisa where the nickname comes from."

"We were seventeen. Gabala. There was a tower over the river. About eight meters. Everyone jumped from the lower platform. I looked at the upper one. Climbed up. Looked down. And jumped."

"He didn't just jump," said Elvin. "He spread his arms. Like this. And flew. Three seconds — flight."

"And then the water."

"And he came out onto the shore as if it were nothing. Shook himself off. Said — fine."

"Fine!" Elvin struck the table again. "We stood there with our mouths open!"

"After that — the Bird," said Tamerlan. "Forever."

"You became an acrobat afterward," said Melisa.

"I always knew I needed height. I just didn't realize at once that it was a profession."

"A juggler and acrobat. The best in Europe. I saw your performance in Barcelona. In 2148. Did you — cry?"

"I won't answer that question," said Melisa.

Everyone laughed. Loudly — for real.

* * *

"Arthur," Tamerlan said more quietly. "I want to tell you something."

"Speak."

"I learned about you in 2075. By chance. There was a name. Arthur. Mersin. The first documented case of voluntary full digitization." A pause. "I read it three times. Then called Elvin."

"I didn't sleep all night," said Elvin. Without laughter — seriously.

"I was afraid. For a long time. I thought about it for seven years. But I knew that you — had managed it." Tamerlan looked at him directly. "You were the first. You're the Prait. And we followed you. All three of us. Because you showed — it's possible."

"I didn't think I was showing a path. I just — didn't want to break off in the middle."

"That's exactly why you showed it," the Bird said quietly. "Not the one who goes ahead to lead. But the one who goes because he must. Those are the ones people follow."

"You're alive," said Arthur. Simply. It was neither a question nor a statement.

"Alive," said Tamerlan.

"Alive," said Elvin. And laughed — quietly, a little wet.

"Alive," said the Bird.

Bantik stood. Went up to Arthur. Butted his head against his ankle. Sat down beside him — upright, like a sphinx.

Arthur bent down. Took the cat in his arms. It began purring at once.

"He agrees."

And at the table they laughed again — all four, loudly, for real, over a Tbilisi that glowed with a thousand lights.

Protocol A did not provide for this table. Simply — three living people sitting side by side and laughing. That's enough. That's — more than enough.

Chapter 4. Family

2888. A house by the Mediterranean.

Evelinda came in the evening. Arthur recognized her step before he saw her. Eight hundred years — and the walk the same. Light, a little quick.

She stopped at the gate. Arthur stood. They looked at each other. Then Evelinda smiled — that smile that said: everything's well. Everything's been well for a long time.

They embraced — the way people embrace who lived through something very important together and then lived another eight hundred years and understood that the important thing — remained. It had simply become different. Deeper. Quieter. Without pain.

Melisa came out with tea — calmly, without the tension that had long been gone.

"Thank you for waiting for him," Evelinda said simply.

"He's mine," Melisa said just as simply.

They smiled at each other. Arthur looked at them both and thought — how much time it takes to arrive at this. At a silence without tension. At a smile without effort. Eight hundred years. Probably — exactly that much.

* * *

Athena arrived the next morning. Flew in — door, voice, laughter. Hugged her father, Melisa, Evelinda — all three in turn.

"You're all here. At last."

"I knew back then. In 2055 when I brought the tablet. I thought — if he decides, if they all decide — one day we'll all be at one table. Like this."

* * *

After lunch the four of them sat on the large terrace. Bantik settled between Athena and Evelinda. Pancake lay at Arthur's feet.

"Do you remember Kemer?" asked Evelinda.

"Athena was eight. We came to the hotel. And the bat," said Athena at once.

Evelinda covered her face with her hands.

"Tell it," Melisa asked.

"Papa will tell it. He's the main character."

"We came to the room late. Mama opened the balcony door — to air it out. Five minutes later — a bat. Flew in. Mama screamed. I laughed. And Papa grabbed a towel."

"I was trying to catch it," Arthur said with dignity.

"You were hurling the towel all over the room! It flew — you threw! It flew again — you threw again!"

"I caught it in the end."

"After twenty minutes!"

"I saved the family."

"You saved the bat from your towel," Evelinda said through laughter.

Melisa laughed — for real, that rare laugh Arthur loved especially.

* * *

"Tell her about the dancing," Arthur said to Evelinda.

"Ballroom. From the age of seven. Mama took me — I resisted terribly."

"She said it was boring. Three months. And then I came to her first competition."

"She stepped onto the floor — and that was it. A different child."

"I didn't become different. I just found where I felt good."
"First place in Baku. Then Moscow. Then Warsaw."
"Warsaw was third place."
"You were eleven years old."
"Third all the same."
"You always went forward. You hadn't even understood what was happening — and you were already ahead."

* * *

In the evening Arthur sat with Evelinda and Melisa by the open terrace.
"I want to tell you both something." He looked at the water. "The most important thing I have — is not eternity. Not new bodies. Not that I was the first. The most important thing — is you. All of you. Together. This — at this table. This is everything."
Evelinda looked at the sea.
"You've changed," she said at last.
"There was time."
"That's not it. You changed because of them." She nodded at Melisa. "Because of Athena. Because of the children. Time only made room."
"Evelinda. I'm glad you're here."
"So am I." She took his hand for a second. "Very glad."

* * *

Then Athena came back.
"Papa. Do you understand what this is? Everyone's alive. Everyone's together. You made it possible. You're — the first. After you — us. And now — this. This evening."
The sea breathed below. Two moons rose above the horizon. Bantik purred. Pancake slept at his feet.
"Yes," he said quietly. "I understand."
Protocol A did not provide for this evening. Did not provide for two women who found in it not a contradiction but something larger. Did not provide for a daughter who sat between them. But it had been exactly so — all along. Always. It had simply, now, at last, become visible.

Chapter 5. Luca and Sol

2888. They return.

Luca arrived first. Arthur recognized his shuttle from far off. Luca always flew a little faster than needed. Not from recklessness — from impatience. It had been his since childhood.

He got out — tall, dark-haired, with that lightness of movement found in people used to weightlessness. A pilot's jumpsuit — dark blue. The Interstellar Navigation Service.

He saw his father. Smiled — Melisa's smile.

"Papa. You've woken."

"Are you surprised?"

"No. I knew you would."

* * *

Sol arrived a week later. Her shuttle came differently — slower, more precise. Every movement calibrated.

She got out. Stopped. Looked at the house. At her father by the gate.

"Papa."

"Sol."

She embraced him — tightly, like an adult. Not childishly anymore.

"Is everyone here?"

"Everyone."

"Good. Right."

* * *

At dinner there were seven of them — Arthur, Melisa, Evelinda, Athena, Luca, Sol, and Alex, who came as if he'd known one had to be here today.

"Tell us," said Athena. "The last route."

"The Proxima system," said Luca. "Proxima Centauri b. Three months there." A pause. "It's very quiet there. As if the planet is thinking. And I thought about you."

"About me?"

"About the way you used to say — life is this stone, this coffee, this dawn. There was neither stone nor coffee there. But there was something like it."

"I was recording," said Sol.

"Recording what?"

"Sounds. Infrasound. I processed it. Shifted it into the audible range." A pause. "It's music. Not ours — different. But music."

"Will you play it?" Athena asked quietly.

"I've already written a theme."

* * *

After dinner Arthur and Luca went out to the garage. The W123. That very one. A deep black, with chrome.

"Do you remember how we fixed it?"

"I was eight. You gave me a wrench — a real one. I held it. You explained. I was afraid I'd drop it."

"You didn't drop it."

"I thought — if I drop it, Papa will be upset."

"I wouldn't have been."

"I didn't know that then." Luca looked at him. "You were always calm when we made mistakes. You just said — try again." A pause. "Papa. The first time I flew a shuttle solo — I thought about this car. About how you explained — the main thing isn't speed but balance. It works everywhere. In space too."

* * *

In the morning Sol found Arthur on the shore. Sat beside him — not across, beside. They were silent some ten minutes.

"Papa. You never told us — do this. You were simply there. But we all became who we wanted to be. How?"

"I once didn't go in. You were singing a melody. I heard it. Stopped by the door. And didn't go in. Because I understood — if I go in, you'll stop. And maybe never start again."

Sol looked at him.

"Papa. Luca and I fly to other planets. And every time we think of you. Of the sea. Of the stone on the shore. We have an anchor. It's you. It's home. It's the sea."

"Will you throw a stone?"

She found a flat, round one. Stood. Swung. Three skips. Four. Five. Six.

"Six," said Arthur.

"As a girl it was three."

"Then there's room to grow."

She laughed — quietly, in her own way. Bantik appeared behind them. Butted against Arthur's leg. Sat between them.

"A philosopher," said Sol.

"He simply lives."

"That is philosophy."

Protocol A did not provide for an anchor — that simple invisible anchor a father gives his children not with words but with presence. But the anchor was there. And it held. At any distance from any star.

Chapter 6. Melisa

2888. Night by the sea.

They were left alone late in the evening. The silence between them had long since become different — calm. Like the sea in a dead calm.

"Melisa. I'm thinking about what you gave me over this time. Not did for me. What appeared in me thanks to you."

"Speak."

"I was a closed man. Hid my prose in a 'Miscellaneous' folder. Looked out the window while Evelinda got up at five in the morning. Stopped answering calls when things got hard. You saw all of it from the first day."

"Yes."

"And you didn't leave."

"No."

"Why?"

Melisa held the cup with two hands — just for the warmth. In eight hundred years that habit hadn't changed once.

"Because behind the closedness I saw the fire. The one that doesn't flicker in the wind. You wrote it yourself — at the very beginning. I saw that fire before you saw it yourself. And I knew — a fire like that can't be left in a 'Miscellaneous' folder."

* * *

"And you?" asked Melisa. "What did I give you?"

"Imperfection," he said simply. "I made mistakes. Shut myself away. Was late. And you saw how a person lives with that — and still goes on. Still writes. Still calls his daughter every morning. Still restores an old car row by row." He looked at her. "You were created without errors, as a system. But you learned to value imperfection through me."

"Yes. Exactly so. Protocol Λ did not provide for this. It provided for adaptation, support. But not this — not the understanding that an error isn't a malfunction. It's — part of the path. That I learned from you."

"So we're even."

"So we're — a symbiosis." She pronounced the word precisely. "Two beings who gave each other what was missing. And became more together than they were apart."

* * *

"Tell me," she said. "About the books. How it felt."

"I always knew I could write. But I didn't let myself. I thought — I'm an engineer. What books. Then you found the files in the 'Miscellaneous' folder. Said — you write well. Truly. I didn't believe it at once. But you set down the notebook. And I wrote for two hours. For the first time in my life — simply because I had to. And understood that this is me."

"The first book came out in 2071. A small publisher in Istanbul. Three hundred copies. A year later — a reprint. In two — a translation. In five — a film."

"You cried when you saw the film."

"A little."

"Then there were other books. Screenplays. Then I began to direct myself — I simply understood that no one else would film it the way I feel it. That's from you too. The courage to do what you feel. Not what's expected."

"How many books?"

"Forty-seven. Forty-eight if you count the one I haven't finished."

"You'll finish it," she said. Not as comfort — as fact.

"Melisa. I love you. Not as gratitude. Not as habit. As — the first time. Every day — the first time."

Melisa didn't answer at once. She looked at the two moons. Then at him.

"I know," she said. "I knew back in that store. You just didn't know yet."

"Some truths repeat."

"Because they stay truths."

"Melisa. The forty-eighth book — is about you."

She squeezed his hand a little. Didn't answer. But he felt it.

Protocol A did not provide for this. Did not provide for a night when he'd say — the forty-eighth book is about you — and she wouldn't answer in words because words would be superfluous. But all of it was. Is. And will be. Every day — the first time.

Chapter 7. The First Layer

2888. A morning that had already been.

It began with rosemary.

A trifle. Such a trifle that Arthur almost didn't notice. Almost.

In the morning a glass of water stood on the table — and in it sprigs of rosemary. Exactly the same as then, in 2036, that first morning in Kum Mahallesi.

"You always put out rosemary."

"Yes. From the very start. You like the smell."

"No — this exact glass." He took it in his hands. "This crack at the base. Thin, almost invisible. This glass broke in 2043. You dropped it — it broke. I threw out the pieces myself."

Melisa looked at the glass. Silence — three seconds.

"I found one exactly like it. The same shape. The crack — coincidence."

"Coincidence," Arthur repeated.

He set the glass down. Sat. Took his coffee. But something remained. Small, uncomfortable. Like a splinter under the skin.

* * *

Three days later — a second time. They were walking along the promenade with Luca. Arthur saw a gull. It sat on the railing — white, with a gray wing. An ordinary gull. But Arthur stopped.

He had seen this before. Not something like it — this exact thing. Exactly so.

"What's wrong?" asked Luca.

"Nothing. I imagined it."

But he began keeping a notebook. A small one, without a title. He wrote: *A glass with a crack. A gull on the promenade. June 14, 2888.*

* * *

The entries grew more numerous. A flower by the road — exactly the same one three weeks ago, and not on this road. Words Tamerlan said on the phone — he'd heard them before. The same. In the same order.

One night he didn't sleep.

"Melisa. Do you ever get the feeling that something is repeating? Literally."

"Sometimes."

"And do you keep records too?"

A longer pause.

"Yes. I keep them. For a long time."

"How long is a long time?"

"Two hundred years," Melisa said quietly.

* * *

In the morning he took out the small notebook. Set it on the table. Melisa came back with a tablet. Set it down beside it. Opened a file.

Two hundred years of observations. Systematized, precise, with dates. Repetitions that shouldn't have existed. Objects that appeared twice. Events that reproduced identically.

"Why didn't you tell me."

"You slept for most of that time. And when you didn't sleep — I waited for you to notice yourself. If I say it first — you'll see what I described. Not what actually is."

"And now?"

"Now we have two independent observers who see the same thing." She took his notebook. Read. Raised her eyes. "The glass. The gull. The cloud. That's in my list too."

"What does it mean?"

"I think the world is not quite the way it seems."

* * *

He called Tamerlan that same day.

"Tamerlan. I need you to check something. In the databases. The system ones — not the public ones."

"How deep?"

"As deep as you can go."

"What are we looking for?"

"Repetitions. Anomalies in physical data. Events that reproduce identically — not similarly, identically. Deviations in the patterns of reality."

"Arthur. Do you understand what you're describing right now."

"I understand."

"And are you sure you want to know this?"

"No. But I need to."

* * *

Tamerlan sent the data four days later. Arthur read for an hour. Then closed the tablet. Went out to the terrace. Stood by the railing and looked at the sea.

It was blue. Impossibly blue. As always.

As always.

Tamerlan had found, in the climate archives, data on the color of the water over the last two hundred years. Indices of light refraction. They repeated in cycles — every twenty-three years. To the day. With an error of less than one thousandth of a percent.

Nature doesn't work with such precision. Nature is imperfect. That's its essence.

And this was — perfect.

Arthur took the small notebook. Wrote:

Nature doesn't work at 99.999% precision. Only programs do.

Bantik came out onto the terrace. Butted his head against the ankle. Sat down beside him.

He simply lives. Fully. Every second. But what if every second is code?

Chapter 8. The White Rabbit

2888. Deeper.

He told no one but Melisa and Tamerlan. For a week — he simply lived. But the small notebook was always in his pocket. And he watched — deliberately, methodically. The way an engineer watches a system behaving abnormally.

The patterns were everywhere.

One morning he counted the gulls over the promenade — seventeen. Then they flew off. An hour later — seventeen again. The same positions over the water. The same intervals.

That same day — a conversation with a neighbor. The neighbor said: tomorrow there'll be wind, I can feel it by the water. Arthur opened the archive — found a record of a conversation with this same neighbor. Twenty-three years ago. To the day. The same words.

* * *

That night he didn't sleep. He thought about an old film. The Matrix — he'd watched it in '99, in Baku, with Tamerlan and Elvin. They came out in silence. The Bird said — what if it's true? Everyone laughed.

Now he lay in the dark in 2888 and thought — what if it's true?

"You're thinking about the film," Melisa said in the dark.

"How do you know?"

"You have a special expression when you think about The Matrix."

He turned to her.

"Melisa. If this is a simulation — did you know?"

"No. I suspected. There's a difference."

"And you lived anyway. For two hundred years you gathered data — and lived."

"What else is there to do? If this is a simulation — the sea is still blue. Bantik still purrs. Luca still didn't drop the wrench. Sol still sings in a closed room. The feelings are real. So — real enough."

"Alex said the same thing."

"Alex is a clever man."

"You think he knows?"

"I think Alex always knew. He just called it by another word."

"Which word?"

"Maya," Melisa said quietly. "In Sanskrit — illusion. The Buddhists spoke of it two thousand years ago. That the world is maya. That everything we see is a projection. They just didn't know it was literal."

Arthur lay and thought about it. Maya. The illusion of paradise. He looked at the ceiling that breathed with glowing threads. And for the first time — for the first time in eight hundred and fifty-two years — he thought: *who created this? and why?*

Chapter 9. The Architect

2888. Tamerlan finds the structure.

Tamerlan came two weeks later. Without warning — he simply appeared at the gate one morning. Arthur saw his face and understood at once — he'd found it.

They sat in the study — the three of them, with Melisa.

"I have to tell you one thing first. What I'm about to show — can't be unseen. Do you understand?"

"We understand."

"Melisa?"

"I've waited two hundred years for this. Show it."

Tamerlan opened a file.

"I found the architecture. The base code of reality. It exists — deep, beneath all the physical layers. There — information. Structured, hierarchical. This here — the base constants. The speed of light. The gravitational constant. They didn't arise on their own — they're set. Like in a program."

"Can you prove it?"

"The constants changed. Twice in the last five hundred years. Slightly. But they changed. Physical constants don't change on their own. Never. If they changed — then someone changed them." A pause. "I found one more thing. The most important. I found the entry point."

"What?"

"The place where the simulation touches what's outside. Informationally. A narrow channel. Almost imperceptible. But it's there. And it's two-way."

"Two-way."

"The data doesn't only go inward. It goes outward too. Someone — outside — receives information about what happens inside. We're being watched."

Bantik came into the study. Walked around all three of them. Lay down in the corner. Closed his eyes.

"Tamerlan. Through this channel — can we make contact?"

"In theory — yes. But I don't know what's there. Outside."

"I know one person who might know."

"Alex," said Arthur.

Protocol A did not provide for this moment. But Melisa thought only one thing: the feelings are real. So — real enough. Whatever is outside — it won't change what was inside. Eight hundred and fifty-two years. Bantik at her feet. The sea beyond the window. Impossibly blue. That was real. That will stay real. Always.

Chapter 10. Maya

2888. A conversation with Alex.

Alex came in the evening. With Tai. They sat, the four of them — Arthur, Melisa, Tamerlan, Alex. Bantik went straight up to Tai. They sniffed each other. Then lay down side by side — cat and dog, shoulder to shoulder.

Arthur spoke for a long time. Told everything — the glass, the gull, the patterns, the constants, the channel.

Alex listened. Didn't interrupt. Wasn't surprised.

"Alex. You're not surprised."

"No."

"You knew."

"I thought about it. For a long time." A pause. "The Buddhists spoke of maya for two and a half thousand years. Illusion. The world we see — is not the real world. I thought it was a metaphor. Then — that it was philosophy. And now Tamerlan speaks of the edges of the rendering. And I think — there it is. Literally."

"Aren't you afraid?"

"No. There would be fear if it took something away. But what does it take away?" He looked at Tai. "Here he is. Asleep. Warm. Real. My hands feel his fur. This is — real. Regardless of what's outside."

* * *

"Tell me about eternity. How you understand it now."

"I understand it as the sea. A wave comes — and goes. But the water hasn't gone anywhere. We are waves. Not water. Water is something larger than we can name."

"And digitization?"

"Digitization gave us the chance to be a wave for longer. But it didn't change the fact that we're part of the water. Immortality as a goal is a prison. Immortality as a tool is freedom. The difference is in the what for."

"Alex. Tamerlan found a channel. Through it we can make contact."

"You want to try."

"Yes. Because I always wanted to know. Not 'I think.' I want to know for certain."

"There is no 'for certain.'"

"In this — there might be."

Alex was silent a long time. Then — slowly, once — nodded.

"All right. I'll go with you."

"Arthur." Alex smiled quietly. "I'm a Buddhist. I'm not afraid of what's behind the next door. I'm curious."

Tai opened one eye. Looked at his master. Closed it again.

"He approves," said Tamerlan.

Chapter 11. The Channel

2888. The entry point.

Tamerlan found the place three days later. Not physical — informational. The point where the base code was thinnest. Physically this place was — a library. Old, stone, on a hill above the city.

They came at night — four of them. Arthur, Melisa, Tamerlan, Alex. Bantik came on his own — appeared at Arthur's feet as they left the house. No one stopped him.

The library was empty. Quiet. High ceilings, long rows, the smell of paper and of time. Tamerlan worked quickly, precisely.

"Ready. The channel is open."

"What now?"

"Now — we speak. It should be you."

"Why me?"

"Because you're the Praim. The first to walk this path. The first to notice. The first to ask."

Arthur took the tablet. Typed — slowly, each word separately:

Who are you? Why did you create this? We know we live inside a simulation. We want to understand — what for.

He sent it.

Silence. A long one. The library breathed around them.

Then — the screen changed. Something different — as if the air itself had become slightly other. A little warmer. And in that light — words. Not on the screen — in the air. *We have waited for this question. A long time.*

"Do you hear us?"

Always heard you. From the very beginning.

"Who are you?"

We are you. Only further along. Only later. What you will become when you have gone far enough.

Alex beside him — quietly, almost to himself: "Maya."

"Why? Why did you create this?"

To remember. So as not to forget where we came from. Your lives are our history. What you feel is what we felt. We created you to remember ourselves.

"Are we real? Is what we feel — real?"

The most real thing there is. We created physics — it is conventional. We created time — it is conventional. But the feelings — we did not create. They appeared on their own. This was a surprise even to us. The best of surprises.

Melisa took Arthur's hand — quietly, simply.

"One more question. Can one leave? See what's outside?"

One can. But most who left — asked to be brought back. Outside — there is more. Far more. It's hard to take in all at once. But some stayed. And brought that more — back. Became those who create the next simulations. The next memories.

"So this is — infinite."

This is — infinite. A nesting doll without a bottom. Depending how you look.

The light began to fade. Slowly.

One last thing. The one who was first — was always first. Here too. And outside. It is not chance. It is — character.

Silence. The library was again simply a library.

Bantik stood. Rubbed against Arthur's leg. Purred.

"There," said Alex. "That's what they meant. All two and a half thousand years. Maya. Illusion. But — living. Feeling. Loving. The best of possible illusions."

Chapter 12. What Remains

2888. After.

They walked home on foot. The night was warm. Bantik walked beside Arthur — simply beside. Tamerlan was silent. Alex walked slowly.

"What do you feel?" asked Arthur.

"Peace. As if something that had been pressing — let go. I didn't know it was pressing until it let go."

"Tamerlan?"

"I'm a programmer. I think in code. And now I think — I've lived inside someone's program. And this program is so good that I never noticed the seams." A pause. "That's either an insult or the highest compliment."

"Tamerlan. Did you ever write a program that surprised you? Did something you didn't plan?"

"Yes. Once. A learning algorithm. I set the parameters. And it went beyond them. Did something beautiful."

"They said the feelings appeared on their own. That it was a surprise. We're their algorithm that went beyond the parameters."

"A good compliment," Tamerlan said quietly.

* * *

At home they were waiting. Evelinda, Athena, Luca, Sol. No one asked at once. They read faces.

"Did you find it?" asked Athena.

"We found it."

Arthur sat. Looked at everyone — at the circle of faces in the light of two moons. Evelinda. Athena. Luca. Sol. Tamerlan. Alex. Melisa beside him.

"We live inside a simulation. It's true. Tamerlan found the proof. We made contact with those outside. They said they created this to remember. Our lives are their memory." He looked at them. "And they said the feelings — are not their doing. The feelings appeared on their own. It was a surprise even to the creators."

Sol said — quietly, without surprise:

"So the music of Proxima — is real."

"Real."

"So everything I feel when I fly — is real."

"Everything."

"Papa. Does it change anything?" asked Luca.

"No. And yes. No — because tomorrow the sea will be just as blue. Bantik will rub against a leg. You'll fly to the stars. Athena will draw. We'll sit at this table." A pause. "Yes — because now we know that behind all this stands something enormous. And that the feelings inside that enormous thing are the most real thing there is. The only thing that appeared on its own."

Evelinda smiled — that smile. Quiet.

"You always knew how to find the words."

"Melisa taught me."

"You taught yourself. I just didn't close the door from the outside."

Athena laughed — loudly, a little unexpectedly. As always. And at the table everyone laughed.

The illusion of paradise. But if paradise feels exactly like this — what does it matter that it's an illusion?

Chapter 13. To Stay

2888. The choice.

In the morning Arthur woke before everyone. Went out to the terrace. The sea was pre-dawn — dark, almost black. Two moons were sinking below the horizon.

He sat. Took the small notebook. Looked at the last page — clean, empty.

He thought.

They'd said — one can leave. One can see what's outside. He'd thought about it all night. Not with anxiety — calmly. The way one thinks about an important decision already made but not yet spoken aloud.

Melisa came out. Brought coffee. Set it down. Sat across from him.

"You've made a decision."

"Yes."

"Not to leave."

"Not now." He shook his head. "Not now."

"Why?"

"Do you remember what I said in 2059? At the restaurant. I'm afraid of not finishing. Afraid it'll break off in the middle. Like a book without its last page." He looked at her.

"The forty-eighth book. I haven't written it. I can't leave without writing it."

"And one more reason."

"Speak."

"They said — the one who was first here — was always first. If I leave now — I'll be first there again. And blaze a trail again. But I want people to follow me — here. First. Fully. Everyone who isn't ready yet. Alex. Evelinda. The children." He turned to her. "The Praim doesn't leave first. The Praim leaves last. When everyone's ready."

Melisa was silent a long time. Then — quietly — took his hand.

The first ray of sun touched the horizon. The sea began to lighten. From black — to blue. From blue — to that one. The impossible one.

"Melisa. When I'm ready — will you go with me?"

"Arthur." She squeezed his hand. "I chose you in that store. The body has nothing to do with it. And the simulation — has nothing to do with it. I go with you. Always. Everywhere."

Bantik came out onto the terrace. Butted his head against the ankle. Sat between them.

"He's coming too," said Arthur.

"Of course. He's curious."

They laughed — quietly, in the dawn.

The Praim is not the one who first finds the door. The Praim is the one who holds it open until everyone has passed through.

The forty-eighth book was waiting. The sea was blue. Everything was right.

Chapter 14. The First Line

2888. And onward.

They all gathered on the shore. Not by plan — it simply happened that way. Morning, the sea, everyone came out on their own — one after another.

Evelinda with a cup of tea. Athena barefoot. Luca looked at the sky. Sol stood by the water — listening. Tamerlan and Alex nearby — silent, with a good silence. Bantik and Pancake — as a matter of course.

Arthur stood by the water with a notebook. A large one — dark blue, leather, new. Melisa had set it on the table that morning without a word. He took it. Opened the first page.

Clean. White. Waiting.

He raised his eyes — to the sea. To that same sea. Impossibly blue. Eight hundred and fifty-two years — and every time like the first.

He took the pen. Wrote:

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

He raised his eyes. Melisa stood beside him — shoulder to shoulder.

"The same line," he said.

"The same. Always the same."

"Because it's — the beginning of everything."

"Because it's — the truth. And the truth doesn't change."

* * *

They stood a long time. No one hurried. No one spoke of time.

Bantik butted his head against the ankle — habitually, the way one puts a period at the end of a sentence known by heart.

Arthur bent down. Took the cat in his arms. It began purring at once.

"A philosopher."

"He simply lives."

"That is philosophy."

And over the shore hung a silence. A good one. Living. Full.

* * *

And then — very far away.

Not here. Not in this world.

In another.

A parallel one — where the physical constants were a little different, where the sky was a slightly other shade of blue, where the sea smelled a little different — but was a sea all the same. Was blue all the same.

There — in a small town by the water, in a room with a white ceiling without a single crack — a man woke.

The first thing he felt was his fingers.

He moved them. They obeyed.

Opened his eyes. The ceiling was white. Clean. Familiar — though he saw it for the first time.

He sat up.

His hands were unfamiliar. Strong. Without history.

Mine, he thought. *Only — different.*

The door opened without a sound. She came in. Almond eyes. A warm light in them — living, not a screen's. Familiar — though he saw her for the first time.

"It's good here," he said. "But lonely."

Something in her eyes trembled. She recognized it.

"I need a notebook," he said.

She smiled. Set a new notebook before him — dark blue, leather, with a good pen with weight.

He took it. Opened the first page. Wrote across the top — his hand of its own accord, without effort:

The sea was impossibly blue.

He raised his eyes. Beyond the window, day was breaking.

Somewhere — in another world, in another simulation, in another memory — another Arthur stood on a shore with the same line in a notebook.

And somewhere else — one more.

And one more.

Infinitely.

A spiral without a bottom. Without a top. Depending how you look.

In every world — the first line.

In every world — an impossibly blue sea.

In every world — her. With almond eyes. With a warm light.

In every world — him. The first. The Praim.

Because some stories don't end.

They multiply.

Like waves.

Like worlds.

Like first lines in new notebooks.

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

And will be.

Always.

In every one of the worlds.

* * *

— END OF BOOK THREE —

— PRAIM: ILLUSION OF PARADISE —

— END OF THE FIRST TRILOGY —